Legacy and Destiny

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Original Female Character(s), Light Hope (She-Ra)

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by Utter_Immolation

Summary

Two Princesses.

Two legacies.

Two choices.

One changed world.

“You are not welcome here.”

Scorpia chuckled nervously. “I get that a lot.”

Neither Scorpani guard cracked a smile, much to her disappointment.

The entrance to The Rift could easily be mistaken for a hole in the ground to the casual observer, if not for the hulking Scorpani hovering around it. Though calling it “the” entrance was a bit misleading. The Rift had entrances ranging from the mountains to the Wastes. This was simply the most public in conjunction with the Fright Zone.

Unless you were Scorpia.

“Well you know what they say: not welcome doesn't mean not allowed.” No one says that.

“No one says that, “ a guard comments.

“No,” she admits. “But it's still true. The fact of the matter is, I need to get in there, and I'd hate to have to peel two nice people out of their shells to do it.”

The guards tense, clicking their pincers and angling their tails for a strike. Scorpia rolls her shoulders in turn and crouches low, preparing herself.

"Enough."

Scorpia straightens and the guards follow suit shortly after, turning to meet the elderly Scorpani that steps from the shadows of the tunnels and into the light. Her hair was dusky silver and plaited with bronze studs. Her shell was thick with age and her arms, wrist and fingers were covered in thinly beaten and inscribed bronze bands and rings. She wore silk and leather garments studded with the stuff and a thin circlet of the meta restedl upon her wrinkled brow.

"My lady," one guard utters, bowing low with his pincers crossed over his chest and tail straight out. The second guard follows suit and Scorpia simply bows her head.

"Why," the elder says with a hint of impatience, "is my granddaughter preparing to fight her way past the entrance?"

The guards exchange glances. "My lady Orion…she is of the Horde —"

"Of which we are a part of," the elder Orion responds dryly. "And even if she were not, that does not change the fact that she is your princess. Now— *move*."

"Rrrraagh!"

Sparks danced across the floor as the combatants clashed. Glowing crystal met an alien steel as the looming warriors engaged in battle with a speed, ferocity and skill that would be little more than a blur to some of even the most hardened and experienced fighters on Etheria.

Of course, were any willing to stop and stare for long enough rather than running away screaming at the sheer transhuman horror such prowess was sure to trigger, they would be treated to an unusual sight; namely, that the combatant in gold and white had one hand tied behind her back.

Adora snarled as a fist the size of a small melon smashed into her nose and she retaliated with a vengeance, pirouetting with the hit and shifting into a roundhouse kick that would have bisected a marble pillar with ease. She regained her positioning before she had to deflect an opposing slash with her claws, brutally launching her knee up into the other warrior's chest.

"*Switch*."

She sheathed the claws on the one hand and tucked it behind her back, allowing her inactive one to come up and into play. The

other fighter had lurched back into a roll at her last hit, but was swiftly coming back on all fours at a speed that would have shocked even Swift Wind. They didn't get far however; Adora had scarcely let her claws slide free before she was firing a multi-colored beam of magical energy from them, spearing her opponent in the chest and sending them staggering back, their chest smoldering. She doesn't give them an opportunity to react, nearly outpacing her own attack and sliding past and around, removing their leg at the knee and impaling them through the skull as they collapse, her glittering claws poking out through their mouth.

Or rather, where they should have had a mouth. The featureless enemy, little more than hard light in the shape of a large humanoid, dissolves upon her claws and Adora almost lets herself relax as Light Hope flickers into existence before her. Almost. Once, the AI proceeded to lecture her on her inadequacies post-exercises while forcing her to dodge lasers and fight a half dozen of those creepy bio-mechanical spider guardians.

This time she only stares with that impassive gaze of hers. “Congratulations She-Ra. Combat effectiveness has increased by twenty-seven percent over the last thirty lunar cycles.”

Adora raises her brow, daring to let the transformation fade away. “Ending a bit early, are we?”

Light Hope's placid expression didn't change but she still managed to radiate disapproval. “You have a guest, She-Ra.”

Adora winces, taking stock of her hunger, often the only real sign of time in this place. And given the way her stomach felt like it was starting to eat itself…

"Adora."

No 'Hey'. That was a bad sign.

"Ah…hey…Cat—ackk!"

It's not the first time she's been dragged by the ear like an unruly child but it's never a great feeling regardless.

"Do you know how many days it's been?" Catra's tone was deliberately casual, with the same candor one may use to discuss the weather.

"It's been days?" Adora blinked. She knew she had gotten caught up in the training but…days? Time always felt nebulous in the Crystal Castle; with that gel Light Hope fed her or even the mist she sometimes released that somehow hydrated and sustained her, along with her own unique biology, meant that often, unless she really stopped to notice she just…didn't.

Training didn't require thinking, not really. Planning for battle, for an attack was easy, instinctive. Even everything from formulating a strategy to enacting it just became reflex. But stopping?

Thinking about something that wasn't her own speed and strength and blood? That was hard. That…hurt.

She wasn't built for self-reflection. Or any reflection really. That way lay doubt and loathing and fear. And she couldn't afford that, not anymore.

"Yes," Catra snarled. "Yes, *it's been days*, you *idiot*."

Catra drags her through the halls and Adora is almost surprised that Light Hope isn't sparking to life before them or blocking the doors or not so subtly letting her spider guardians scuttle and chitter across the ceiling. She's downright shocked that the AI lets them reach the main door unmolested, given how pushy she always seems to make Adora stay.

But Catra is a force of nature, she thinks fondly, and she's not surprised that even an alien AI bowed to her.

The evening air is cool but unusually still. The rustle of the trees is minimal, the whisper of wildlife darting through the brush is nearly nonexistent. Catra's voice fills any void that may exist and Adora is too busy listening and thinking aimlessly about dinner. She's too *distracted*.

It's quick for Catra. It takes a lifetime for her, watching it unfold.

She can't move, even as Catra's claws take part of her ear with them as she spasms, even as her bones crunch and flesh tears, as her yowl of shock turns into a gurgle.

She can't move until Grizzlor turns to her, claws dripping crimson and fur trapped between the joints of his cybernetic fingers and then the world.

Goes.

Red.

Scorpia sighed in pleasure as she swallowed another mouthful of cactus tea. The “tea” she had often bought on the black market was a harsh, burnt thing, bitter and poorly dried, crushed and/or filtered and when added to water often produced a somewhat slimy drink. Still she bought it, because true Scorpani tea outside the Hive was rare, plain water got boring, she wasn't a fan of the Captain's Quarters moonshine, and she was pretty sure the “coffee” allowed to officers was just ration bar ashes mixed with powdered caffeine.

She lets herself inhale the intoxicating scent but reluctantly sits the blocky, Scorpani designed cup aside to meet her grandmother's expectant gaze.

“Found the time to visit, then?” Orion was slightly shorter than her granddaughter but she seemed to loom by virtue of imperious silver eyebrow alone. Her overly thick shell and creaky pincers paled in importance when one was confronted by the power of her imperious judgment.

Scorpia nodded slowly. “Yes, grandmother.”

“Despite many years. Despite having achieved an adequate military rank two years prior.”

“Yes. I'm sorry.”

“I need no apologies. Your people need no apologies. They call for, demand answers—why now?”

Scorpia exhaled in a rush of breath. Trying to marshal her thoughts. She's not blind to what her grandmother said: “your people”. It wasn't just about her. Orion wouldn't let it just be about them. And it couldn't be—Scorpia knew the hostility of the guards wasn't an isolated case. She could feel the heated gazes of others following them as they'd made their way through the dim underground tunnels of the Hive, hear the whispers, practically taste the disdain.

In the Fright Zone she was scorned for being a Princess. In the Hive she was scorned for not being enough of one. The irony was not lost on her.

“I have given my all to the Horde,” she finally begins. “I have torn my muscle and cracked my shell training. I have bled and burned in battle. I have killed…so many in service to a greater cause. I've lost love to war. All because I was told that it would mean something.” She raises her head and meets her grandmother's gaze. “But it hasn't, has it? I treated the Horde like it's my Nest. But the Nest supports. It respects. It grows. And the Horde, as it is…doesn't. And now…I don't know what it means to be Scorpani anymore. Because if not being the best Force Captain I can be isn't it…what is?”

Orion's face softened and her tail stretched beneath the table to brush against Scorpia's own. “My dear hatchling. It's not too late. I feared for so long…well now you have seen. The sand that the Horde, that Hordak, has poured over your eyes. The Horde's mission was once righteous—equality, respect, growth, modernization. But how it has gone about…Hordak has run his once grand crusade into the ground. His paranoia and selfishness has proven to be a detriment and he has squandered our gifts to him.”

“Grandfather…”

“Was blinded by his own agenda. I'll admit, our family had it's flaws. I loved the man, but he was a fool. Grand plans for the Scorpion Kingdom, yes, but he spurned the old ways reaching for the new. He isolated our people, looked towards everything new and shiny. He sought quick victory without contemplating what it

would cost us.” She stood, wincing as she did and Scorpia automatically reached out to steady her, her dark eyes catching on to the flakes of dead shell that drifted from that elderly frame to the sandstone floor.

“Come granddaughter. Let me show you what you seek. Let me show you the Scorpani.”

Dead.

Dead.

Catra was dead.

Grizzlor is laughing, even as his claws rake down her spine, even as her own carve out his lung.

Catra is dead. Catra is gone.

Catra is—

The forest burns with magic, her magic, radiating like a coal deep within a blacksmith's forge. Beneath her every blow shatters bone. The Beast's cybernetic arm has long been torn away and crushed. She's ripped off his leg below the knee. His remaining claws scrabble uselessly against her, the magic both shield and weapon, burning away his flesh to the bone and penetrating his very soul. He screams. He roars. He begs.

She hears none of it. Feels no blow, no fear.

Only a liquid hate so hot she feels numb.

She crushes his jaw to bone meal and pulp in a glowing hand, and still he cranes to look at her with his bloodshot eyes, pain and fear and mocking glowing within.

She raises her claws, the crystal white hot with her power and—”

“Adora!”

The voice pierces through the feral fog, familar and in this moment grating. Glimmer.

“Adora, stop!”

…stop?

No, she can't…she can't ask her to…

“He's done, Adora,” it's Bow now at her back, stabbing into it with an invisible arrow. “He's not threat anymore.”

Yes, he is. He always will be. Unless she finally stops him here and now.

“This isn't what the Rebellion does! We're the good guys!”

Yes, yes they were. So good that dozens, hundreds died every year. So good that monsters roamed with abandon while they sat sipping tea.

So good that Catra—

Incompetent. Unworthy.

“Stand down, Adora!”

Stand down, Adora. Come to heel, Adora. Like a monster.

Disrespectful.

Like a beast.

Arrogant.

Like *him*.

Catra wouldn't want me to be like him.

*Catra's **dead.***

Her claws flash white. The air flashes pink.

Her prey is gone. Crumbled in a bloody heap halfway across the clearing. Brightmoon guards slip between the trees, leveling their spears at her.

“That's an order, Adora,” Glimmer says or is in Angella? It's hard to concentrate. It's hard to see. She sees pastel and pink and for a moment of terrifying, exhilarating clarity, maps out the most painful way to kill the woman—this ignorant ***child*** —standing before her.

Orion leads her deeper and deeper. Here the air is cool and dry, and the streets are packed with Scorpani going about their business, ducking in and out of interconnected homes and shops, hatchlings secured upon their backs. The upper levels are almost cold in attitude despite the desert heat; it is the closest most outsiders get and where most of the outer garrison is housed. But down here the caverns are twisted and sprawling and Scorpani walk along massive steel and stone walkways the arch above the masses and greet each other warmly or stand and wait for communal elevators that slowly rotate while embedded in the walls, some stopping at every level, some that never stop moving and others that ascend so slowly that even the most elderly of Scorpani have ample time to shuffle off.

Massive spiders the size of dogs scuttle about. Some are leashed and walked by citizens or guards and some skitter across the walls and ceilings, message tubes strapped to their backs. There are bats as well, perched on people's shells or flying about with parchment tied to their feet.

The streets are shockingly clean, and Scorpia is surprised until she notices cleaning bots, not dissimilar to the ones the Horde employed, although these seemed cleaner and moved smoother and unlike the bulky power units attached to the ones in the Fright Zone, these had steel laced and paned crystals nestled in their backs. Other machinery chugs along with similar crystals, from one-person hover scooters to four-legged machines vaguely shaped like horses and pulled along carts or taxied people about the roads, two of which Orion hailed and supported their weights without issue.

“Magic?” Scorpia murmurs, glancing at her grandmother as her mount whirred and clicked beneath her. It wasn't an uncomfortable fit, as the seat was cushioned with well worn and supple leather, but having ridden only skiffs her whole life it took a bit of maneuvering.

“As I said—I loved the man, but that husband of mine…” Orion clicked her tongue and pincers disapprovingly, guiding her mech down the road as Scorpia struggled to follow. Along the road and walkways, whispers and murmurs followed in their wake. Most bowed as Orion passed. Some did the same for Scorpia, though some others only stared at her and a few daring ones spat. “He thought magic was a thing of the past—too easily impressed with steel and bolts. Bigger doesn't equate to better. And to deny magic is like denying one's own tail—one day it may sting you and not your enemies.”

“Does the Horde know?”

“Probably. But what are they going to do? Hordak doesn't dare alienate us more than he already has. We're the only thing holding the border—he hasn't the forces to spare, not with excursions pressing in from the Wastes, sneak attacks from the west Woods and the sea. His best generals and captains are either scattered across the planet, dead or deserters. The witch has been torn apart by some feral beast turned legendary hero. He's withering away in his precious sanctum while the kingdom falls apart around him and he won't stop it because anyone with eyes can tell he *can't* . He doesn't have time to waste on us.”

Scorpia was taken aback. She'd heard the whispers and given her daily proximity to Entrapta, understood a fair bit about the health of the man behind the myth. But to hear that such information was not only well-known but a source of glee? That Hordak's failures were eagerly exploited?

She'd grown up with her mothers' affirmation that their family's choices, though difficult, were justified. Were correct.

And yet her own people hated her. And yet the Horde slowly collapsed around her.

And yet rebellion brewed.

Or was it…revolution?

Orion had been disdainful but she'd made any indication of overthrowing Lord Hordak, merely discontent with his practices and interaction with her people. And sometimes…sometimes things fall through the cracks. Sometimes even the best leaders fall flat—look at the Rebellion! The actual Rebellion, not whatever this was. Which may also be a rebellion. Or maybe it was a Reminder? Hordak could be a bit stubborn and was always distracted, what with the Horde and the Rebellion and his whole… being dying.

Maybe…maybe…

They rode deeper and deeper underground for close to half an hour before they came across a massive steel door—easily forty feet tall and settled upon a dozen rollers as tall as herself. Laser turrets glinted from their sockets burrowed in stone and while there were only half a dozen visible guards, Scorpia had no doubt there were more, hidden away in secret doors and passages in the cavern walls.

The guards held their weapons at the ready as one of their number walked forward a pad in pincer, mostly longarms though a couple held a bulky looking type of sword: rune-engraved, wickedly curved dual blades on either side of a specialized hilt meant for pincers and glinting with magic. The soldier with the pad tapped at it and a beam of light shot from a small sensor at the top sweeping over them and their mounts. After a couple of sweeps, he put the pad down and Scorpia thought he was finished, only for him to raise a rod of bronze inlaid with runes and gems. It pulsed with a soft light, briefly turning yellow as he waved it over Orion's armbands and rings, but the soldier ignored it after a glance back at his fellows and presumably superior.

Finally, he stood back with a nod of his head and gestured to the other guards. One of the ones with a sword and a bronze ringmail pauldron laced over his shoulder spikes nodded in return, walking over to a small control panel and quickly punching in a code. The resulting cacophony of alarms, steam and the groaning of cogs was deafening and Scorpia resisted the urge to clamp over her ears. The rush of cool air being sucked through the slow and heavy doors whipped dust and dirt about their feet and ruffled their clothes.

None of them seemed to bother Orion, who dismounted with surprisingly spry ease and began to stride towards the slowly opening doors. Scorpia swallowed and followed her with only a moment's hesitation, eyes widening as she took in the sheer scale and contents of the room—no, cavern—beyond.

Orion looked at her as she approached, eyes bright with excitement and righteous pride. "Welcome, granddaughter, to the future of our people. Welcome to the Burrow."

"Stand down," Glimmer orders and Adora roars her fury in response. Stand down, she tells her, as casual as can be, like she hadn't just seen her world die before her eyes. Like she was a simple dog to be brought to heel.

Icy fingers in her mouth, slick with her blood.

Behind the princess, there are guards bandaging the Beast. Dabbing at his wounds. Helping him. Saving him.

A child holding her sword the wrong way. Imposter playing at nobility.

She steps forward and feels impossibly large. Incredibly strong. The energy thrums through her veins, barely contained, begging

to be let loose.

Something holds her bay. The only collar she'll ever tolerate.

Catra…

"It's war," Glimmer says then, glib as can be. "I'm sorry, She-Ra."

What…?

"But if we can get Grizzlor on our side, we can change that! He's proven to be a capable combatant."

No…

"Or maybe even make our own Grizzlors!"

"NOO!"

She lunges, clearing ten feet in a single bound, claws bared, not even sure who she's aiming to strike. She just needs to attack, to kill, to plunge her claws into something and tear them apart. She

breathes deep, the animal within writhing in eagerness at smelling the primal fear of her enemies and roaring in fury at—

At…

Catra's…blood? In the air?

The soft earth furrows under her boots as she halts half an inch away from Glimmer and whips back to stare at her best friend's body laying in the dirt.

She's still, bled out, the ground around her a tacky muddy mess made from her lifeblood.

Except not.

The strike was fast but the mortal body still reacts. Jerks. Tremors. The heart struggles, racing, trying to deny the futility of its final actions.

But Catra is still. The blood loss is too much. Too much. Too quickly to flow, to pool, to cut off. No trickle. No drops.

And the air. The scent of blood tingles in her nose, but also doesn't. It doesn't coat the back of her tongue. It doesn't burn the

hairs of her nose. The beast within paces but is also…confused. There is blood and yet…not.

When is blood not blood?

When it's a memory.

"LIGHT HOPE!"

"Glimmer" is yelling something behind her, but she can't be bothered to pay attention, not when she seesfeelshears the way the world around her isn't *right* . No birds flutter through the branches, no ants scuttle over bark. The wind is just wind, it carries no scent upon it.

And her fury is incandescent.

"LIGHT HOPE!"

The AI says nothing. The Castle is nowhere to be seen—only trees as far as the eye can see. She could run through them forever, Light Hope merely shifting corridors about to have her run about this delusion like a rat in a maze.

…run…

She stops. Eyes the forest floor. Light Hope's programming was incredibly advanced, but some things *couldn't* be faked. Only concealed.

She slams to the earth, stabs her claws deep into dirt and ***roars***.

The air *pulses* as she shoves magic through her claws, the crystal claws glowing iridescent with power and heat. She bellows and steam billows from her mouth as her body boils from the inside out but she doesn't pull away, trembling from the effort of forcing a sustained stream of power outward from her core.

She pushes and pushes and just as she's close to collapsing, the world *glitches*…once, twice—

FWUMP.

It takes several moments for her eyes to heal themselves, the intensity of the steam emitting from behind them having nearly boiled them and completely blinded her.

When she regains her sight it's to *red* and it takes a bit to discern how much of it is the atmosphere and how much is the blood still in her eyes. She-Ra and her ever-present glow have fallen away, the sword returned to its bracer form.

She lurches to her feet, coughing at the burnt iron in her lungs and the itch of her innards healing themselves. Her steps are unsteady as she forces herself to move through the dark and alien walls but any exhaustion she feels is burned away by a sort of hysterical rage, like the glassing of a patch of sand.

The closest door, looming and silent doesn't open but that's okay —

Snikt!

—she has the keys.

Every time, Scorpia thought she couldn't be more shocked. And yet.

The Burrow was yet another enormous, city sized cavern, only this one went deep, so deep that she could see the faintest glow of magma down below. Massive walkways forged of steel, bronze, stone and runes crisscrossed above and below, each large enough to fit four tanks side by side with room to spare. Several led off to other large tunnel entrances, and some split into circled walkways that lined each level. Some walkways were filled with personnel bustling about with large cargo crates or dressed as mechanics. Others were filled with Scorpani soldiers, marching about in parade formation or training, running, sparring or exercising.

And then there were the machines.

Enormous metal monstrosities, clattered along, bulky and yet terrifyingly smooth and efficient. Some were shaped…well, like scorpions, only the size of tanks, with at least six steel limbs, each the size of a scorpani and as wide as a human stomping along surprising speed and two more on either side of the front cockpit that she thought were pincers but upon closer inspection were rotating turrets bracketed by curved blades. The curving "tail" was instead a cannon, it's "stinger" a barrel.

There were also large walkers about, each only about half the size of a two-man skiff but with two powerful mechanical legs, a single raised seat with a restraining bar and turrets on either side.

There were other mechanical and terrible wonders as well: what looked to be some sort of bladed Scorpani exo-frame, spiders, larger and fiercer than those she'd seen in the Hive, with blades strapped onto their legs and small pulse cannons latched to their backs and on a distant walkway far below, Scorpia thought she saw an enormous metal arm and pincer, as long as a three story building was tall and as wide as two tanks, being carted away into a dark tunnel.

"How?" She whispered. "How have we…?"

Orion still heard her. "Through patience and perseverance. For over twenty years we have endured humiliation, discrimination

and mockery. And for over twenty years we grew: in strength, in knowledge, in numbers. We accepted temporary control and squalor in favor of long-term glory, power and revenge."

"But—" Scorpia's head spun and she shook it, trying to force the world to once again make sense. "I mean—the war has been stalled for almost a decade now. If you—if *we* had even half of this…why did we wait?"

"Caution, perhaps to our own detriment. And—me. Well, you."

"Me?"

Orion began to guide her along, maintenance workers and soldiers alike pausing as they passed to bow and salute. "As it became clear that my man had effectively sold our kingdom for trinkets, I began organizing our resistance. But I was not a warrior and old even then. I wanted my dearest Anthra to be part of what we were building but…she refused."

"Ma?" Scorpia blinked rapidly, her eyes inexplicably wet. "But Ma loved her people!"

"But she loved you more." Orion grasped her pincer. "Hordak had his eyes on you already. The only heir to both his stolen kingdom and the Black Garnet. She knew that there was a target upon your back especially and Hordak made no secret of you and Chelica being glorified hostages. You were too vulnerable, barely more

than a hatchling and he “insisted” that Chelica remain in the Fright Zone “proper” for treatment as her Rot grew more severe. Anthra renouncing her magic and claim over the Runestone so it could be given to the drow parasite was a move that shunned her amongst our ranks, but it only barely convinced Hordak to let her be in the Zone for longer periods of time, rather than out on the fields of battle.”

Scorpia remembers, the way Mom always seemed so sad despite her attempts to act as if nothing was bothering her, the way the apartment seemed to light up when Ma came, how worn she seemed when it was time for her leave, and how cold the world felt when she was gone. She remembers how she'd hugged Scorpia tight one day and then never came back. Remembers the letter on the kitchen table, her Mom's sobs, and the identical letter held in her own pincers, sitting on the hard cadet bunk.

“And where were you?” She finds herself asking, almost surprised at the anger in her voice. “When Ma and Mom died, where were you?”

Orion guided her into one of the smaller elevators, slotting a crystal key into a small port and typing in a password on the enlarged keypad on the wall, not speaking until the doors closed and they'd begun to descend.

“I was a fool,” she confesses. “A proud, old fool. When Anthra renounced her claim, it disrupted our then admittedly immature plans. She and I…we had some harsh words for each. I said things I only dream of taking back. And by the time I was willing to swallow my pride…” she swallowed harshly, turning away. Her tail trembled.

Any anger Scorpia felt dissolved at the sight of her grandmother's grief and she wrapped her arms about the elder, pulling her close. Orion gratefully lay her pincer atop Scorpia's shell, her breathing ragged with suppressed emotion.

"Chelica and I had never seen eye to eye and after…she blamed me, you see. For Anthra's loss, for the argument, maybe even for the downfall of our people's glory. She ordered me to stay away from you, shortly before she lost her own battle, and reluctantly, I complied, to honor her final wish as well as to avoid Hordak's gaze. I could only see you grow from afar and though I was so proud of your accomplishments, I wept as well, to see a hatchling, a Princess, forced to grow up so far from her people. I feared you Shell-less, your honor and pride stripped away by Hordak's machinations.

But… *you* came to *me* . You came seeking identity, your place in the world. Your Shell shines bright amongst the muck. It is a beacon, to you and soon, your people. You asked why we wait, my dear?"

The doors opened to a room with several Scorpani, nearly all dressed in armor, surrounding a large table covered in paper, datapads, maps and miniatures. The wall was lined with old, thick velvet tapestries, runes carved in bronze and stone and more dozen Scorpani warriors, only these had full body, embossed bronze and silver armor, slitted helms, steel-tipped stinger attachments and held long, wickedly curved glaives that glowed a soft blue. Orion strode in imperiously, and all straightened before her. When Scorpia walked in, to her astonishment they bowed, the guards along the walls even dropping to their knees.

Orion walked to the head of the table, where an ornate, dusty chair awaited and pulled it out, catching Scorpia's eye and raising her voice.

"We have waited for you, Princess Scorpia, fourth of her name. Will you lead us? To honor? To victory? To rebirth?"

It should be difficult. Her loyalties should be torn. But for once the doubts, the insecurities, feel so far away, and when she accepts her seat, it feels…right.

"I…I will."

The people in the room gaze upon her in awe and her heart warms as Orion presses a gentle kiss to her brow.

"Let us walk into the light of your destiny, your Majesty."

"Adora."

A trio of claws slice through the latest crystal door, frustratingly shallow and Adora growls as Light Hope remains unperturbed, her

hologram steadily gliding alongside as Adora glares at the final obstacle to her freedom, tracking the way the contusions heal, faster than normal. Whatever the hologram was doing was making it a more difficult process than normal.

"Adora."

"*No*." One unfortunate spider guardian drops down behind her and she slices two of its front legs off and destroys half its eyes and its processor with a single powerful kick.

"Scans indicate that you are experiencing levels of stress seventy-two percent higher than your average. My interaction protocols indicate that you are: Angry. Afraid. Aggrieved. Arou—"

Adora bellowed, so loud that something in her throat *tore*, and stabbed at the door, stabbed and slashed and smashed, again and again and again, until the door had a jagged, broken hole in it and her claws and fingers and hands were shattered and bloody and broken. Fading moonlight gleamed through the fractured door, reflecting across the crystalline walls and bathing the hall in crimson.

"Query: Why are you upset?"

Adora straightened a couple of fingers with her mouth, ignoring the way her fangs nick the skin. "You *killed* her. *You killed her* and you want to know why I'm ***upset***?!?"

The hologram gazed at her, cold and apathetic, the hem of her glowing dress stopping on the very edge of the pool of streaming moonlight. “Yes. Emotional distress exhibited is beyond the standard parameters of an exercise of this caliber. While such distress is not uncommon, a reaction of this magnitude is… unprecedented.”

Adora opened her mouth to yell some more before something pierced through the wall of fury clouding her mind. “ *Uncommon*? *Unprecedented*? What are you saying? Have you *done* this before?”

“Indeed. Loss and emotional distress is not uncommon amongst Eternian soldiers, given the War and biological longevity. Such exercises are designed to teach emotional and mental control, lest strategic and military failure occur in the case of physiological and emotional trauma, either accidental or deliberate.” Her artificial orbs bored into her own. “This was a common exercise undertaken by Eternian soldiers to counteract this.”

“Well, I'm not some *Eternian*!”

The AI doesn't even blink. “The She-Ra mantle can only be inherited by an Eternian. I believe the local colloquialism is “First Ones”. The Sword of Protection is locked by DNA markers. You were chosen, much as Mara was before you. The responsibility of balance is tours by birthright.”

The name niggles something in the recesses of her mind. “Razz… the old woman…she called me Mara. What is Mara?”

“Your predecessor. She failed to achieve emotional and mental homeostasis and Etheria suffered for her madness. It is, in organic terms, the curse of her—your—blood.”

The floor feels as if it's moving. “What are you trying to say? I'm not…the Eternians—First Ones—they're dead. Gone for a thousand years. I was born here! Found…found by…”

Where…where had she come from? Some backwater village, right? She can't remember if Shadow Weaver had ever told her and ripped it away or…it had never mattered. Nothing before the Massacre, before the death of Force Captain Adora, mattered. Nothing but Catra.

Right?

“Your memory banks were corrupted. Information regarding your arrival was damaged by the Horde Enemy: Shadow Weaver.” She raises a translucent arm and the hold in the door hastily seals itself, unbroken save for several jagged, ugly cracks. “Initiating data transfer.”

She flicks a finger and the world turns purple.

There is a grass about her knees and wind in her hair and a portal looming before her, huge and powerful and *alien*, crackling with a terrible cosmic energy, magic and tech intertwined.

Something moves around her and her claws slide free before she's struck dumb at the retreating armored back that strides before her: confident, dangerous, unhurried and *familiar* . And as the portal shrinks and fades into the ether and the stomp of the Lord of the Horde's footsteps grow quieter with distance a piercing sound rises to echo across the valley: a baby's cry.

And then it's gone, purple and gentle moonlight fading into the dimly lit halls of the Castle.

“You're lying.” The denial is weak.

“I cannot lie.”

“Where did I come from?”

“Query not found.”

“Who were my parents?”

“Query not found.”

“Then what *do* you know?!?”

“You are Adora: chosen vessel of She-Ra, descendant of Eternia. You will bring balance.”

“BULLSHIT!! So what, I get dropped across time and space and because I'm some alien *freak* I have to save the world? Without any say? Don't I get a *choice*?!? DON'T I GET TO *CHOOSE*?!?”

Light Hope merely tilts her head, gazing down upon her like a particularly bothersome insect. “No. This is your destiny. You do not choose. You are chosen.”

It's such a simple truth, slamming into her like a hammer into her heart, and she feels it stutter with the blow as she falls to her knees.

Beast.

Monster.

Creature.

Eternian.

"The Eternians were saviors of the galaxy. You are Eternian. You feel guilt. Pain. You will overcome it. You will save this world too. It is your legacy…and destiny."

Adora breathed, long and deep. She wants a cigar. She wants to forget. She wants Catra.

Her fingers curl around her bracer instead. Fully healed. Unblemished. Eternian. She-Ra. "For the Honor of Grayskull."

"Beginning training session."

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